



GROWTHSCHOOL • GEN AI BOOTCAMP

Getting Started with n8n

Session notes — your quick-reference guide to understanding and building automations with n8n.

FORMAT

Session Notes / Guide

LEVEL

Beginner-Friendly

READING TIME

10–15 minutes

01 What is n8n?

n8n (pronounced "nodemation") is a free, open-source workflow automation platform. Think of it as a visual programming tool where you connect different apps and services together — without writing code.

If you've heard of Zapier or Make (formerly Integromat), n8n does the same thing — but gives you far more control, and you can self-host it for free.

Why n8n?

- **Visual & no-code** — drag, drop, and connect nodes on a canvas.
- **400+ integrations** — Gmail, Slack, Notion, Sheets, OpenAI, databases, and more.
- **AI-native** — built-in nodes for LLMs, AI Agents, vector stores, and RAG workflows.
- **Free tier** — generous cloud plan; or self-host with zero cost.
- **Community** — active forums, templates, and thousands of shared workflows.

Key Concepts — The Building Blocks

Before you touch the n8n canvas, get comfortable with these five terms. Everything in n8n is built from them.

● Workflow	A complete automation — the full chain of steps that runs when triggered. Each workflow lives as its own project in n8n.
● Node	A single step in your workflow. Each node does one thing: read an email, call an API, transform data, send a message, etc.
● Trigger	A special node that <i>starts</i> a workflow. It listens for an event — a new email, a scheduled time, a webhook call — and kicks everything off.
● Connection	The line that links one node to the next. Data flows along connections from left to right, output → input.
● Expression	A dynamic value written as <code>{{ \$json.fieldName }}</code> . Expressions let you reference data from previous nodes instead of typing static text.

02 The n8n Interface — A Quick Tour

When you open n8n, you'll see a clean canvas with a toolbar. Here's what each area does:

- | | |
|--------------------------|--|
| ● Canvas | The large central area where you place and connect nodes. Drag to pan, scroll to zoom. |
| ● Node Panel (+) | Click the + button or press Tab to search and add nodes. You can search by app name ("Gmail") or by action ("Send message"). |
| ● Executions | The log of every time your workflow has run. Click any execution to see what data flowed through each node — invaluable for debugging. |
| ● Workflow Toggle | The Inactive / Active switch at the top right. Flip it to Active to make your workflow run automatically. |
| ● Credentials | Stored under Settings → Credentials . This is where your API keys and OAuth connections live (Gmail, OpenAI, Slack, etc.). |

Pro Tip: Keyboard Shortcuts

Tab → Open node search | **Ctrl/Cmd + S** → Save | **Ctrl/Cmd + Enter** → Execute workflow | **D** → Disable/enable node | **Backspace** → Delete selected node

03 Your First Workflow in 5 Minutes

Let's build something real — a simple workflow that triggers on a schedule and sends you a Slack message (or email) every morning. This teaches the core mechanics.

Step by Step

- 1 Create a new workflow.** Click **" + Add Workflow "** from the dashboard. Name it **"My First Automation"**.
- 2 Add a Schedule Trigger.** Press **Tab**, search for **"Schedule Trigger"**, and add it. Set it to run **every day at 9:00 AM**.
- 3 Add a Set node.** Press **Tab** → search **"Set"** → add it. This lets you define the message content. Add a field: Name = **message**, Value = **"Good morning! Time to check your tasks."**
- 4 Connect the nodes.** Drag from the Schedule Trigger's output (right dot) to the Set node's input (left dot). You'll see a line connecting them.
- 5 Add a Gmail node.** Press **Tab** → search **"Gmail"** → add it. Set Resource to **Message**, Operation to **Send**. Connect your Gmail credential. In the **To** field, enter your own email. In the **Message** field, click and type: `{{ $json.message }}`
- 6 Test it!** Click **"Test Workflow"** (top right). Check your inbox — you should have the morning message. If it works, toggle the workflow to **Active**.

What Just Happened?

You built a three-node workflow: **Schedule Trigger** → **Set (data)** → **Gmail (action)**. Every n8n automation follows this same pattern — a trigger, optional data transformation, and one or more action nodes. The complexity grows, but the pattern stays the same.

04 Adding AI to Your Workflows

n8n has first-class support for AI. You can plug in OpenAI, Google Gemini, Anthropic Claude, or local models — and use them as thinking engines inside any workflow.

The AI Nodes You'll Use Most

NODE	WHEN TO USE
AI Agent	Best all-rounder. Understands context, can use tools, and chains reasoning steps.
OpenAI Chat Model	Direct access to GPT models. Use as a sub-node inside AI Agent.
Basic LLM Chain	Simple prompt → response. Great when you don't need agent reasoning.
Text Classifier	Categorise text into labels (e.g., "urgent" vs "low priority").
Sentiment Analysis	Detect whether text is positive, negative, or neutral.
Summarisation Chain	Condense long text into short summaries.

Connecting Your OpenAI Key

- 1 In any AI node, click **"Create New Credential"**.
- 2 Paste your OpenAI API key (from [platform.openai.com](https://platform.openai.com/api-keys) → API Keys).
- 3 Choose your model — **gpt-4o-mini** is recommended for speed and cost.
- 4 Click **Save**. The credential is reusable across all your workflows.

5 Workflow Ideas to Try Next

- **AI Email Replier** — Auto-draft replies to incoming emails using AI. (See our dedicated workbook!)
- **Slack Summariser** — Summarise daily Slack messages and post a digest each evening.
- **Lead Qualifier** — When a form is submitted, use AI to score and categorise the lead.
- **Content Repurposer** — Feed a blog post URL → AI generates LinkedIn post + tweet + email.
- **Meeting Notes Bot** — Record a meeting transcript → AI extracts action items → creates tasks in Asana.

05 Quick Reference & Resources

n8n Terminology Cheat Sheet

TERM	MEANING
Workflow	Your complete automation (collection of connected nodes)
Node	A single step / action in the workflow
Trigger Node	The starting node — listens for an event to begin the workflow
Action Node	A node that does something (send email, create record, call API)
Expression {{ }}	Dynamic values that reference data from previous nodes
Credential	Stored API key or OAuth token for connecting external services
Execution	A single run of your workflow (logged with full data)
Webhook	A URL that triggers your workflow when called by another app
Sub-workflow	A workflow called from within another workflow (for modularity)

Helpful Links

RESOURCE	URL
n8n Cloud (sign up)	https://app.n8n.cloud/register
n8n Documentation	https://docs.n8n.io
Workflow Templates	https://n8n.io/workflows
Community Forum	https://community.n8n.io
OpenAI API Keys	https://platform.openai.com/api-keys
n8n YouTube Channel	https://youtube.com/@n8n-io

You're ready to automate.

Start small, build one workflow, and expand from there.
Every automation you create saves future-you hours of manual work.

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